

Lesson 1 - Turkish Basics

Turkish Alphabet - All 29 Letters

8 vowels (A, E, I, I, O, O, U, U) · 21 consonants

A B C C D E F G G H I I J K L M N O O P R S S T U U V Y Z

Note: Turkish is **phonetic** – you write as you speak! Every letter has **one** sound (no silent letters except G).

Vowels - Pronunciation Guide

A a

Like a in *father*

araba = car

E e

Like e in *bed*

ev = house

I i

Like the e in *open* (no dot!)

isik = light

Deep throat sound

I i

Like ee in *meet*

iyi = good

O o

Like o in *more*

okul = school

O o

Like French *eu* in *feu*

ogrenci = student

Pucker lips!

U u

Like *oo* in *boot*

ucak = plane

U u

Like French *u* in *tu*

uzum = grape

Kiss lips!

Special Consonants

C c

Like *j* in *jellyfish*

cam = glass

Always hard j

C c

Like *ch* in *chair*

cay = tea

G g

"Yumusak **ge**" - silent

yagmur = rain → "yaa-mur"

Lengthens previous vowel

S s

Like sh in *shark*

sise = bottle

J j

Like French j in *je*

jilet = razor blade

Soft zh sound

Greetings

Turkish	English
Merhaba!	Hello!
Benim adim [name].	My name is [name].
Senin adin ne?	What is your name?
Nasilsin?	How are you? (informal)
İyiyim, teşekkürler.	I'm fine, thanks.

Good Morning / Evening / Night

Turkish	English	When?
Gunaydin	Good Morning	Sunrise - 12:00 PM
İyi Akşamlar	Good Evening	Sunset - Bedtime
İyi Geceler	Good Night	Only when going to sleep

Tip: Don't say "İyi Geceler" at 8 PM - the waiter will think you're going to bed! Use İyi Akşamlar.

Sen vs Siz

Sen = informal (friends, family, people your age)

Siz = formal (elders, strangers, teachers, or "you all")

Always use "Siz" with people you don't know.

Personal Pronouns

Pronoun	Meaning	Example
Ben	I	Ben öğrenciyim. (I am a student.)
Sen	You (informal)	Sen nasilsin?
Siz	You (formal)	Siz nasilsiniz?
O	He / She / It	O iyi.
Biz	We	Biz iyiyiz.
Onlar	They	Onlar iyiler.

Buffer Y rule: İyiyim = İyi + -yim (the 'y' bridges vowels because Turkish avoids two vowels together!)

Dialogue 1

Ali: Merhaba! Nasilsin?

Ayşe: Merhaba! İyiyim, teşekkürler. Sen nasilsin?

Ali: Ben de iyiyim. Teşekkürler.

Ali: Hello! How are you?

Ayşe: Hello! I'm fine, thank you. How are you?

Ali: I'm fine too. Thank you.

Dialogue 2 - Asking the Time

A: Affedersiniz, bir soru sorabilir miyim?

B: Buyrun.

A: Saat kaç?

B: Saat üç.

A: Excuse me, can I ask a question?

B: Go ahead.

A: What time is it?

B: It's three o'clock.

Exercises

Fill in the blanks:

I = _____ (answer: **Ben**)

You (informal) = _____ (answer: **Sen**)

You (formal) = _____ (answer: **Siz**)

He / She / It = _____ (answer: **O**)

We = _____ (answer: **Biz**)

They = _____ (answer: **Onlar**)

Practice dialogue:

You: Affedersiniz, saat kac?

Stranger: Saat on bir. (11 o'clock)

You: Tesekkurler. İyi aksamlar!

Stranger: İyi aksamlar!

Basarilar! (Good luck!)

Turkish is phonetic – read it as you see it!